

MARCH MADNESS 2026 ML PREDICTIONS

	R64	R32	Sweet 16	Elite 8	Final 4	Champ
East	(1) Duke (16) Siena (8) Ohio St (9) TCU (5) St John's (12) N Iowa (4) Kansas (13) Cal Baptist (6) Louisville (11) S Florida (3) Mich St (14) ND State (7) UCLA (10) UCF (2) UConn (15) Furman	⌋ (1) Duke Conf: 64% ⌋ (8) Ohio St Conf: 55% (9) TCU ⌋ (5) St John's Conf: 64% ⌋ (4) Kansas Conf: 61% ⌋ (6) Louisville Conf: 56% ⌋ (3) Mich St Conf: 83% ⌋ (7) UCLA Conf: 55% ⌋ (2) UConn Conf: 64%	⌋ (1) Duke Conf: 60% ⌋ (5) St John's Conf: 61% ⌋ (3) Mich St Conf: 59% ⌋ (2) UConn Conf: 61%	⌋ (1) Duke Conf: 59% ⌋ (2) UConn Conf: 53%	⌋ (1) Duke Conf: 59% (2) UConn	
	(1) Florida (16) PV A&M (8) Clemson (9) Iowa (5) Vanderbilt (12) McNeese (4) Nebraska (13) Troy (6) UNC (11) VCU (3) Illinois (14) Penn (7) St Mary's (10) Texas A&M (2) Houston (15) Idaho	⌋ (1) Florida Conf: 64% ⌋ (9) Iowa Conf: 50% ⌋ (5) Vanderbilt Conf: 61% ⌋ (4) Nebraska Conf: 60% ⌋ (6) UNC Conf: 56% (11) VCU ⌋ (3) Illinois Conf: 62% ⌋ (7) St Mary's Conf: 58% (10) Texas A&M ⌋ (2) Houston Conf: 64%	⌋ (1) Florida Conf: 58% (9) Iowa ⌋ (5) Vanderbilt Conf: 52% ⌋ (3) Illinois Conf: 54% ⌋ (2) Houston Conf: 56%	⌋ (5) Vanderbilt Conf: 50% (9) Iowa ⌋ (3) Illinois Conf: 56%	⌋ (3) Illinois Conf: 59%	⌋ (1) Duke Conf: 55% (2) UConn
	(1) Arizona (16) LIU (8) Villanova (9) Utah St (5) Wisconsin (12) High Pt (4) Arkansas (13) Hawaii (6) BYU (11) Texas (3) Gonzaga (14) Kennesaw (7) Miami (10) Missouri (2) Purdue (15) Queens	⌋ (1) Arizona Conf: 95% ⌋ (9) Utah St Conf: 51% ⌋ (5) Wisconsin Conf: 53% (12) High Pt ⌋ (4) Arkansas Conf: 60% ⌋ (6) BYU Conf: 55% (11) Texas ⌋ (3) Gonzaga Conf: 83% ⌋ (7) Miami Conf: 56% ⌋ (2) Purdue Conf: 89%	⌋ (1) Arizona Conf: 57% ⌋ (4) Arkansas Conf: 61% ⌋ (3) Gonzaga Conf: 55% (11) Texas ⌋ (2) Purdue Conf: 56%	⌋ (1) Arizona Conf: 57% ⌋ (2) Purdue Conf: 52%	⌋ (1) Arizona Conf: 52%	⌋ (1) Duke Conf: 51% (1) Michigan
	(1) Michigan (16) Howard (8) Georgia (9) St Louis (5) Texas Tech (12) Akron (4) Alabama (13) Hofstra (6) Tennessee (11) SMU (3) Virginia (14) Wright St (7) Kentucky (10) Santa Clara (2) Iowa St (15) Tenn St	⌋ (1) Michigan Conf: 63% ⌋ (8) Georgia Conf: 55% (9) St Louis ⌋ (5) Texas Tech Conf: 58% ⌋ (4) Alabama Conf: 61% ⌋ (6) Tennessee Conf: 58% ⌋ (3) Virginia Conf: 64% ⌋ (7) Kentucky Conf: 57% ⌋ (2) Iowa St Conf: 62%	⌋ (1) Michigan Conf: 59% ⌋ (4) Alabama Conf: 53% ⌋ (6) Tennessee Conf: 57% ⌋ (2) Iowa St Conf: 60%	⌋ (1) Michigan Conf: 54% ⌋ (2) Iowa St Conf: 55% (6) Tennessee	⌋ (1) Michigan Conf: 51%	⌋ (1) Arizona Conf: 51% (1) Michigan
	Bracket accuracy: 49/63 (77.8%)					
	ESPN score: 1020 / 1920					
	Chalk accuracy: 42/63 (66.7%, 820 pts)					

MODEL PERFORMANCE ON UNSEEN TOURNAMENTS

Trained on 2009-2022 (864 games). Tested on 2023-2025 (201 games).

Model	Test Acc	AUC	Overfit
LightGBM	75.6%	0.804	-2.0%
XGBoost	74.6%	0.789	-2.2%
CatBoost	73.6%	0.805	-1.6%
RF (Random Forest)	73.1%	0.805	+3.1%
Chalk (higher seed, coin flip on tie)	72.1%	N/A	—
LogReg	71.1%	0.797	-1.2%
MLP (Multi-Layer Perceptron)	71.1%	0.796	-1.1%
SVM (Support Vector Machine)	70.6%	0.801	-0.6%

MODEL METHODOLOGY

CORE PREDICTOR

Logistic Markov Chain
Composite Ranking (LMC)

The LMC ranking aggregates 100+ individual ranking systems into a single composite via a logistic regression / Markov chain model. It is the strongest single predictor of tournament outcomes in our feature set.

SUPPORTING FEATURES (8)

- Offensive Rating
- Offensive Rebound %
- Defensive Rating
- KenPom Rank Volatility
- Offensive Rating Volatility
- Win Percentage
- Free Throw %
- Turnover %

MULTI-MODEL CONSENSUS BRACKET

Most-picked winner across all 7 models per matchup

	ELITE 8		FINAL 4		CHAMP
E	(1) Duke	(7/7)	(1) Duke	(7/7)	(1) Duke (4/7)
	(2) UConn	(7/7)			
S	(1) Florida Vanderbilt	(6/7)	(1) Florida Houston · Houston · Illinois · Illinois	(3/7)	Arizona · Arizona · Michigan
	(3) Illinois Houston · Houston	(5/7)			
W	(1) Arizona	(7/7)	(1) Arizona	(7/7)	(1) Duke
	(2) Purdue Gonzaga · Gonzaga	(5/7)			
MW	(1) Michigan	(7/7)	(1) Michigan	(7/7)	
	(2) Iowa St Tennessee · Tennessee · Tennessee	(4/7)			